

5.e) Total Institution

good writing
The concept of total institution was given by Erving Goffman in his book "Asylums: the social situation of mental patients and other inmates" (1961).

Concept

Total institutions are closed social systems where life is regulated by a central authority with strict rules, procedures and schedules through use of force.

(e.g.) Prisons, Military bases.

Types of Total institutions

Given by Goffman in 1957 paper.

1) Those that provide care who cannot do it themselves.

(e.g.) Orphanages

2) Those that provide care to those who may be a threat to society. (e.g.) Psychiatric centres

3) Those that keep people who are perceived threats to society. (e.g.) Prisons.

4) Those that provide education

(e.g.) Boarding schools.

Relevant point

- 3) Those that provide resort for religion, spirituality
 (e.g) Monasteries.

Characteristics

- 1) Totalistic world → All interactions inside with all same people
- 2) Inmate world — Mortification process as one enters total institution.
 (e.g) Clothes taken
- 3) Privilege system — Incentives for good behaviour
- 4) Adaptive capabilities — Various individuals react differently.
 (e.g) Turning inmates, rebellion

Criticisms

- Susan Scott argues that with advances in technology, the concept not relevant in original form.
- Methodological errors.

Despite ~~concerns~~ criticism, the concept gave perspective to see various facilities from a new lens.

Good.

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